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CLARENCE "SKIP" ELLIS

COMPUTER SCIENTIST, GROUPWARE

Ellis was the first African American PhD in computer science. A pioneer of “groupware,” which allows several users to collaborate on a document, he also helped develop the idea of clickable icons. As a teen in Chicago, Ellis guarded a mainframe computer at night and became a self-taught expert by reading the manuals. He earned a scholarship to study Math & Physics at Beloit College, where he helped set up the college’s first Computer Lab. Ellis worked at some of the most prestigious companies & universities, including Xerox, IBM, Los Alamos Scientific, Stanford, MIT & UC Boulder. He preferred to teach undergraduates with little experience in Computer Science because he wanted to encourage students of all backgrounds to stretch their academic abilities and consider a career in computer science. Ellis was passionate about civil rights, mentoring students from HBCUs & teaching in Africa.

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